Prime Minister whether he should invade Cuba. Macmillan pondered the question overnight, and wrote the following day, Thursday, 25 October, counselling against invasion. The Prime Minister's preference was increasingly geared toward some kind of conference (where he no doubt intended to play a prominent role).

History books

A well-established part of the missile crisis narrative is that President Kennedy was influenced by Barbara Tuchman's Pulitzer-prize winning account of the outbreak of the Great War.[67] *The Guns of August* portrayed how European leaders had stumbled into disaster in August 1914. War came through inadvertence rather than intention. Kennedy had long been convinced that miscalculation was the path to catastrophe. Tuchman's book crystallised some of his concerns and reinforced his views about the conduct of international relations. At the Vienna summit, Kennedy had emphasised the danger of 'miscalculation' to Khrushchev. According to Robert Kennedy, his brother told him that, 'We were not going to misjudge, or miscalculate, or challenge the other side needlessly, or precipitously push our adversaries into a course of action that was not intended or anticipated.'[68]

Many writers have lauded Kennedy's concern to avoid pushing Khrushchev into a corner and instead provided him with a way of saving face (or as Sun Tzu recommended, building a golden bridge behind his adversary over which he could retreat). An alternative approach to golden bridge-building was proffered by Curtis LeMay. 'The Russian bear,' he asserted, 'has always been eager to stick his paw in Latin American waters. Now, we've got him in a trap, let's take his leg off right up his testicles. On second thoughts, let's take off his testicles, too.'[69] Whether it was prudent to build a golden bridge behind Khrushchev or whether the chance to rip off Khrushchev's testicles was a missed opportunity, raises important questions about the outcome of the crisis and what lessons might be learned. These issues have loomed into focus with the Russian invasion of Ukraine and are discussed in chapters seven and eight.